

The 6:15

TUESDAY · AUGUST 18, 2026

NO. 5

THE BOARD

CALENDAR (NEXT 10 DAYS)

Tue 8/18	Home Depot (HD) premkt, cons. EPS \$4.71–4.73; Alaska top-four primary (Sen: Sullivan vs. Peltola); Florida GOP gov. primary (Donalds favored)
Wed 8/19	FOMC July minutes, 2p ET; Target, Lowe's, TJX premkt; Wyoming primary
Thu 8/20	Walmart, Deere, Ross Stores premkt; jobless claims
Tue 8/25	Intuit, Dick's Sporting Goods report
Wed 8/26	Nvidia aft. close, cons. rev ~\$91–95B; Salesforce, CrowdStrike aft. close; July PCE, Q2 GDP (2nd est.), durable goods, 8:30a (BEA); Lisa Cook's deadline to respond to removal letter
Thu 8/27	Marvell aft. close; jobless claims; Jackson Hole opens (thru 8/29)
Fri 8/28	Fed Chair Warsh's first Jackson Hole keynote

Next FOMC decision Tue 9/16, outside window. OPEC+ next JMMC 10/4, outside window.

METRICS · ET UNLESS NOTED

Brent (ICE front)	\$91.02, +0.17% (6:18a); Mon. settle \$90.87, +2.7%
WTI (NYMEX front)	\$84.13, +0.47% (5:41a), Oct. contract post-roll (vs. ~\$85 cited elsewhere for Mon. — unreconciled)
Brent–WTI spread	~\$6.89
UST 2Y/10Y/30Y	4.19% / 4.74% / 5.32% (secondary mkt, ~6a) (vs. Treasury.gov Fri 8/14 official 3.98%/4.51%/5.25% — gap widening)
DXY	99.63, +0.06% (5:44a)
S&P / Nasdaq-100 futures	-0.48% / -1.20% (6:09a, delayed)
VIX	15.19, +6.60% (Mon. cash close)
Gold (spot)	\$4,451.15, -0.50% (6:20a)

Asia (Tue close)	Nikkei 69,136, +0.61%; Hang Seng 25,435, +1.3%
Europe (live, ~6:20a)	DAX 26,440.31 +0.53%; FTSE 100 10,750.11 -0.21%; CAC 40 8,599.87 +0.24%
Retail gas (AAA)	\$4.0656/gal (8/18), ~flat vs. \$4.0636 (8/17)

Crude: ICE Brent front-month, NYMEX WTI front-month, Investing.com real-time. Rates: TradingEconomics secondary market vs. Treasury.gov official close — divergence has widened since Friday, still unreconciled.

HORMUZ COUNTERS

Closure	Day 170 (straits.live, 10:12 UTC 8/18)
Transits vs. baseline	1 vessel/day (8/9) vs. 73/day pre-crisis (IMF/PortWatch AIS, lag persists, no fresher figure published)
Daily crossings	3 on 8/16, down from 19 on 8/11, -19.5% wk/wk (MarineTraffic)
Weekend transits	5 Sat 8/15, zero Sun 8/16, vs. 31 prior weekend; 5-day avg. 12 vs. ~130/day pre-war (Kpler)
Strikes, 24h	Vessel struck by unidentified projectile, 09:48 UTC 8/18, crew member injured (straits.live, single-sourced)
Strikes, cumulative	~56 (UKMTO) / ~61 (secondary aggregation) / ~65 w/ 17 killed (press-attributed IMO) — unchanged since last issue
Dark tankers	55 of 193 AIS-screened dark, past 24h, vs. 62.0 7-day avg. (straits.live) — first sub-baseline reading in weeks
War-risk premium	30.0x pre-crisis; ~\$10.0M/VLCC passage (straits.live, stale since ~8/5)

PortWatch counts AIS vessel movements with a multi-day lag; MarineTraffic and Kpler track daily commercial crossings by differing vessel-inclusion rules; straits.live blends broker war-risk quotes with dark-ship detection at varying refresh rates. Four different universes — don't average or net them against each other.

TRANSACTIONS

Yankees, Knicks, Northwestern	No reported moves in the last 24 hours.
--------------------------------------	---

LEAD

60 DAYS, NO DEAL

The US-Iran deal clock ran out Monday. Trump answered by threatening to bomb Oman.

The 60-day window Washington gave itself to convert June's ceasefire memorandum into a lasting Strait of Hormuz settlement expired Monday with no agreement and no extension. [NEW] Asked directly whether he'd extend the June 18 MoU, Trump said "No," then told Fox News's Trey Yingst that if Oman "gets in the way" of reopening the strait, "we'll bomb the s*** out of them" — a threat aimed at a longtime US partner that has spent the crisis trying to broker exactly the reopening Washington says it wants. [fact: quotes dated 8/17] [read: naming Oman, not Iran, as the obstacle is the tell — Washington's frustration has shifted from Tehran's intransigence to the mediator's inability to deliver terms Iran will actually honor, seven weeks after the MoU promised a settled outcome]

Iran's Foreign Ministry offered a sliver of the deal Trump wants credit for: spokesman Esmail Baghaei said Tehran and Oman had reached "an understanding...regarding the map of the transit route" — the same routing-only progress reported Friday, now confirmed from Tehran's side. [DEVELOPING] But the IRGC moved to close off the backchannel Trump has repeatedly cited, calling his claims of informal talks with the Guard "fantasies caused by delusions" and denying any US contact. [NEW] The split — a civilian ministry conceding technical progress while the military wing denies talking to Washington at all — reads as the same factional gap this brief has tracked all month, not a new rupture. [read] The Oman threat itself is a break in kind, not just degree: this war has run through months of strikes, sanctions and rhetoric aimed at Iran directly, but Trump had not previously threatened to bomb a third-party Gulf state acting as mediator. Oman has hosted the only sustained US-Iran channel of

the entire crisis; making the mediator a target, even rhetorically, raises the question of who is left to carry messages between Washington and Tehran if Muscat steps back. [read]

The shipping numbers back the stalemate rather than any thaw. Two trackers converge on the same collapse: Kpler counted 5 vessels transiting Saturday and zero Sunday, against a 31-vessel prior weekend and a pre-war baseline near 130/day; MarineTraffic's daily count shows crossings falling 19.5% week-on-week, from 19 on Aug. 11 to 3 on Aug. 16. [NEW] Neither captures the last 24 hours: a vessel was struck by an unidentified projectile at 09:48 UTC Tuesday with a crew member injured, per straits.live's tracker — the latest in a strike pattern Iran hasn't paused despite, or perhaps because of, the deadline pressure. [NEW, flag: single-sourced]

Oil is the cleanest read on how the market is pricing this. Brent settled Monday at \$90.87, up 2.7% on the day, and is bid to \$91.02 (+0.17%, 6:18a ET) Tuesday morning — within a couple dollars of the year's highs and up roughly \$8 from three weeks ago. WTI is messier post-rollover: the front-month contract shifted from September to October on Aug. 16, and the freshest quote available shows \$84.13 (+0.47%, 5:41a ET), putting the Brent-WTI spread near \$6.89, though Monday's session move was reported elsewhere as a smaller +0.6% to roughly \$85 — treat the exact WTI level as still settling out post-roll. [flag: WTI unreconciled]

Equities did not shrug this one off the way they did the "territory of the United States" rhetoric a week ago. S&P futures were down 0.48% to 7,731.50 and Nasdaq 100 futures down a sharper 1.20% to 29,735.50 as of 6:09a ET, delayed data — a genuine risk-off move rather than the grind-higher-anyway pattern that held through last week's data misses. The VIX's Monday cash close, 15.19, up 6.60%

on the day, is the clearest single number for the shift in mood: still a low absolute level, but the largest one-day jump the index has logged since this crisis began escalating again. [read: the market spent two weeks treating oil-driven inflation risk as a Fed problem for September; an actual acceleration in strikes plus a threat against a US ally reads as a supply-shock problem first, rate problem second] Gold, often the crisis hedge, actually fell 0.50% to \$4,451.15 as rising Treasury yields — the 10-year secondary-market quote near 4.74%, close to a 19-month high — competed for the same safe-haven bid. Whether that yield move is inflation fear, AI-driven bond supply, or both is Wednesday's question, when the FOMC's July minutes land at 2p ET.

What to watch from here: whether Muscat responds publicly to the bombing threat, which would turn a rhetorical flare-up into an actual diplomatic rupture with a state that has had zero prior friction with Washington this war; whether the "understanding" on the transit-route map produces an actual reopening timeline or stays permanently one level below the political conditions Iran says must come first; and whether Tuesday's projectile strike turns out to be part of the same pattern as the ADNOC-fleet hits last week — concentrated on specific national flags — or reverts to the more diffuse targeting of earlier months. None of those three answers itself in this issue; each is a plain follow-up for tomorrow's Board. [read]

POLITICS

Alaska and Florida vote today in primaries [NEW] with direct market relevance beyond the horse race. Alaska's top-four nonpartisan primary — the state's third cycle under the format voters

adopted in 2020, sending the four highest finishers to a ranked-choice November general — sets the field for a competitive Senate race between two-term Republican incumbent Dan Sullivan and Democrat and former Rep. Mary Peltola, alongside an open governor's race since term-limited Mike Dunleavy can't run again, plus most of the state legislature. Florida Republicans choose a nominee to replace term-limited Gov. Ron DeSantis, with Trump-endorsed Naples Rep. Byron Donalds favored in what's been described as a bitter intra-party fight; Wyoming also votes statewide Wednesday. [NEW] Both races carry weight beyond their states: Alaska's Senate contest is one of the cycle's genuine Republican-held toss-ups, and a Peltola win would tighten the math the GOP needs to hold its Senate majority in November, while Florida's governor's race sets the tone for how far a Trump endorsement carries in a state primary against well-funded intraparty rivals. None of these results will be known before this issue goes to press — Alaska in particular counts slowly under ranked-choice rules, so a clean read may not arrive for days; watch for what's called in tomorrow's Board. The Lisa Cook removal fight and the House-Senate government-funding gap (Dec. 4 House version vs. Dec. 11 Senate version) are unchanged since last issue — no new filings or statements this run. [DEVELOPING, no update]

ECONOMICS

Wednesday's FOMC July minutes (2p ET) are the next scheduled catalyst. The Fed held its target range at 3.50%–3.75% at that July 28-29 meeting, with three dissenters favoring a hike rather than a cut — a hawkish tilt on the committee that the minutes should flesh out in more detail than the post-meeting statement did. [NEW: dissent count and range not previously carried in this brief] CME FedWatch

showed roughly a 69% probability of a September hold as of Aug. 14, broadly consistent with the 31–33% cut odds carried last issue — no fresher snapshot verified this run. [flag: no Aug 17–18 update confirmed] The more interesting economics story this morning is happening in the rates market rather than the data calendar: the Treasury secondary-market 10-year quote has drifted up to roughly 4.74% from Friday's official 4.51% close, with commentary attributing the move to both persistent inflation concern and heavy AI-capex-linked corporate bond issuance. [DEVELOPING] The 2s10s spread, at roughly +55bp, remains solidly uninverted — a hold-consistent curve shape, not a recession-warning one. [read] Nothing on the official government data calendar prints before Thursday's jobless claims.

BUSINESS

Home Depot's premarket print, due 6a ET against consensus of roughly \$4.71–4.73 EPS and \$47–47.5B revenue, was not confirmed as of press time. [flag] The stakes are real: HD stock has fallen 10.7% over the past 52 weeks against an 18.9% gain for the S&P 500, options markets were pricing in a 4.3% post-earnings move, and comparable sales were up just 0.6% last quarter — remodel and renovation spending, not new construction, is now the category's primary growth lever with housing affordability still suppressed. [NEW context, not previously carried] Elsewhere, AI-infrastructure consolidation accelerated: Stripe agreed to acquire model-routing startup OpenRouter for more than \$7B — up sharply from the roughly \$1.3B valuation it carried at its May Series B — with OpenRouter routing traffic across 400+ models for about 8 million developers and reporting some 1.5 quadrillion tokens processed over the past year. [NEW] Separately, Nvidia is reportedly nearing an

agreement to guarantee roughly \$100B in credit backing another OpenAI data-center buildout, per The Information — unconfirmed by either company and distinct from Nvidia's still-unsigned \$500B financing MOU from Aug. 10. [NEW, flag: single-sourced] Nvidia guaranteeing debt that ultimately buys Nvidia chips is the same circular-financing structure critics flagged when the \$500B MOU first surfaced; a second, separate arrangement of similar shape would be one more data point for that read rather than a new argument. [read] Groq disclosed a \$350M raise and Wispr Flow a \$280M Series B Monday. [NEW, flag: not cross-verified beyond initial reports] This week's retail-earnings cluster (TGT/LOW/TJX Wed., WMT/ROST Thu.) still doubles as the first consumer-health read since Friday's retail-sales miss.

TECHNOLOGY

Z.ai's GLM-5.3, released Aug. 14, is the most recent frontier-tier model release turned up this run — a Chinese lab shipping on a cadence now comparable to the US majors, worth watching alongside Gemini and Grok's release pace rather than as a one-off. [DEVELOPING, four days old but not previously reported] [read] Google retired its legacy Imagen 4 image-generation endpoints on Aug. 17, redirecting callers to its Gemini image model — consolidating its image stack under the Gemini brand rather than running a separate product line. [NEW] Anthropic's August risk report raised its self-assessed catastrophic-misalignment rating from "very low" to "low," attributing the change to increased overall uncertainty rather than any specific failed evaluation — a self-graded shift, not the result of an incident. [NEW] Microsoft's reported 300,000-plus-unit Maia/TSMC order remains unconfirmed

by either company, unchanged since Aug. 11. [flag: single-sourced, unchanged]

GEOPOLITICS

Russia and Ukraine traded another heavy overnight exchange, part of what regional coverage described as one of Ukraine's largest aerial attacks of the war on the Russian side of the ledger. [NEW] Ukrainian missile and drone strikes on Russia's Belgorod region killed at least six and wounded four, including a 14-year-old, in the border village of Koloskovo; separately, Russian forces hit nine-plus Ukrainian regions with 128 attack drones per the Ukrainian air force, killing two and injuring 19, and struck port infrastructure in Odesa, damaging a Togo-flagged civilian vessel — the strike on the Danube corridor a reminder that the grain- and goods-export route matters to the war's economics even when Hormuz dominates the oil headlines. [NEW] [read] Russia has now struck Ukraine's Naftogaz facilities 13 times in the past week alone, nearly 300 times since the year began — a sustained energy-infrastructure campaign, not a new escalation spike, and one running in parallel with the Hormuz disruption rather than in response to it. [DEVELOPING] Ahead of Xi Jinping's September state visit to Washington — the follow-up to Trump's May trip to Beijing — the two sides have revived a tit-for-tat sanctions exchange, with Beijing unveiling new measures against US firms it frames as retaliation for "erroneous" American moves; the two governments are separately said to be preparing an AI-focused dialogue ahead of the summit, though how much diplomatic capital Washington has left for that agenda, mid-Hormuz-crisis, is an open question. [DEVELOPING] [read]

IRAN & HORMUZ

Beyond the MoU's expiry, Tuesday brought several fresh data points on how far the disruption has spread. Straits.live's tracker separately logged a crew fatality following a vessel attack and engine-room fire, on top of the projectile strike and injury already in the Board — the vendor's page doesn't fully disambiguate whether these are the same incident or two, so treat the fatality as unconfirmed pending a clearer report. [NEW, flag: single-sourced, possibly duplicative of the Board's 24h strike line] Drone attacks hit facilities linked to Iraqi Kurdish officials on Aug. 17, reportedly launched from across the Iran border, with no casualties reported. [NEW, flag: single-sourced, motive unconfirmed] In the Red Sea, Houthi forces claimed a ballistic-missile strike Monday on a Saudi military landing ship, saying they caused "complete burning" and the sinking of accompanying vessels — a claim not independently verified by any Western source found this run. [NEW, flag: single-sourced, Houthi claim only] Both sit alongside, not on top of, the Bab el-Mandeb fatalities and Kumzar-area strike already reported this week; cumulative Hormuz strike counts remain divergent by source (see Board) and unchanged since last issue. Dark-tanker activity actually eased: 55 of 193 AIS-screened tankers went dark in the past 24 hours, below the 62.0 seven-day average (straits.live) — the first sub-baseline reading this brief has carried in weeks, though one day's data shouldn't be read as a trend reversal. [NEW]

SPORTS

Yankees	Off day. Last: W 4-3 (10 inn.) vs. Toronto, Sun 8/16. 69-55, 2nd AL East, 6.5 GB Tampa Bay.
Knicks	Off-season, no game.
Northwestern	Off-season, no game.

Continuity. Dropped as unchanged since Issue No. 4: the "territory of the United States" rhetoric and prior Hormuz weekend-transit figures (now superseded by fresher Kpler/MarineTraffic reads); the identical Lloyd's List weekly transit figures for the week of 8/3–8/9 (no fresher weekly print available yet); Josh Hart's unsigned-extension status; the Bessent sanctions-timeline quote; CoreWeave/Cisco/Applied Materials earnings detail; the USS Abraham Lincoln crew-morale story and CENTCOM's Cooper quote. Carried forward unchanged: cumulative Hormuz strike counts, the war-risk premium (still stale from ~8/5), and the Cook/funding-standoff status. For tomorrow: confirm Home Depot's actual print against the ~\$4.71–4.73 consensus carried here unconfirmed; watch for Alaska/Florida/Wyoming primary results; watch for the Kurdish-facility drone attack's attribution to firm up beyond the single source carried here; and expect this issue's WTI and 2Y/10Y/30Y reconciliation flags to still be open tomorrow absent a settle-level snapshot.

Unverified figures are marked in red. Nothing was estimated or filled from memory.